

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Donald Trump claimed that “an [agreement](#) has been largely negotiated” with **Iran**. The president said he had “a very good call” with leaders in Saudi Arabia, Pakistan, Turkey, Egypt and other regional powers. He added that “the Strait of Hormuz will be opened.” An Iranian foreign ministry spokesperson said the two sides have edged closer to finalising a memorandum of understanding to end the war.

Officials said that American secret-service agents returned fire on a gunman near the **White House**, killing the individual. The suspect, reportedly a 21-year-old known to the service, approached a checkpoint to enter the complex and drew a gun. A bystander was hit and injured, although it has not yet been revealed by whom. Mr Trump was in the White House at the time but was unaffected a spokesperson said.

Russia attacked **Ukraine** with hundreds of missiles and drones, killing four people and injuring at least 50 in Kyiv, Ukraine’s capital, and other regions including Kharkiv and Odessa. Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine’s president, said Russia had used its multi-warhead Oreshnik hypersonic missile, which it has done just

twice before. The attack comes as Russia falters [on the battlefield](#), and its leadership looks increasingly beleaguered at home.

SpaceX completed a largely successful test of its next-generation Starship rocket, which blasted off from southern Texas two days after the company [filed to go public](#). Despite some engine trouble, the spacecraft that NASA wants to use to land astronauts on the Moon released 20 mock Starlink satellites, before coming down with an (expected) explosion in the Indian Ocean.

A gas explosion in a coal mine in northern **Shanxi** province killed at least 82 people. Officials had previously put the figure at 90. Xi Jinping said that lessons must be learned from the incident, which happened on Friday night. Chinese coal mines once accounted for thousands of deaths every year. However in recent years thousands of mines have been closed and safety has improved, even as [output has increased](#).

The World Health Organisation raised the threat from the Democratic Republic of Congo's **Ebola** outbreak from “high” to “very high”. The suspected death toll in central Africa has reached 177; a further 750 cases are suspected. Scientists are working on a vaccine for the disease, but it is not expected to be ready for several months.

A team from North Korea won the **Asian Women's Champions League** football tournament, which was held in South Korea. Naegohyang Women's FC were the first North Korean football team to visit the South in eight years, prompting huge interest across the region. They beat Tokyo Verdy Beleza in the final and have qualified to play in next year's FIFA Women's Champions Cup.

Word of the week: Amorphous silica, the substance that gives opals their shimmer. An Israeli startup wants to blast tiny spheres of it into the stratosphere to dim the sun and [cool the planet](#).



Photograph: Getty Images

Shehbaz Sharif visits China

China's president, Xi Jinping, will host yet another world leader this week: Pakistan's prime minister, Shehbaz Sharif. Hot on the heels of Donald Trump and Vladimir Putin, Mr Sharif will join Mr Xi to commemorate 75 years of the two countries' "all-weather" strategic partnership. They have both long shared a rivalry with India, but this visit comes at a delicate moment. As Pakistan has stepped up efforts to mediate the stalemate between Iran and America, Mr Sharif wants Mr Xi's support. Asim Munir, the Pakistani army chief held talks in Tehran on Saturday.

The Pakistani leader also wants to court more Chinese investment, as China has slowed its infrastructure splurge under its Belt and Road Initiative. And Pakistan has moved closer towards Mr Trump's America, co-operating more on critical minerals, cryptocurrency and counter-terrorism. Mr Sharif will be hoping his ability to talk to both China and America could help bring the Iran war to an end.



Photograph: Enhanced Games

Inside the Enhanced Games: dope and glory

On Sunday around 50 athletes will [gather in Las Vegas](#) for the inaugural Enhanced Games, a glitzy spectacle in which swimmers, weightlifters and sprinters compete for up to \$25m in prize money, using performance-enhancing drugs. Bonuses of \$1m are on offer for world records. The closing ceremony will feature The Killers.

But the event's real prize won't be on the podium. Enhanced, the company behind the competition, is using it as an advertisement for its other business: selling performance-enhancing drugs, like those for "healthy ageing" and "sharper mornings". It aims to use its athletes' feats to push the boundaries of what consumers consider acceptable enhancement. But if enhanced athletes fail to break world records in Vegas, the event may be quickly forgotten about. If the games are a success, however, more and more people may soon be wagering their bodies on a chance to turn back the clock.



Photograph: Reuters

Tensions ahead of the French Open

The French Open begins in Paris on Sunday. But some of its fiercest battles have been happening off-court. Top tennis players are locked into a dispute with the big four “grand-slam” tournaments, arguing that their prize pots make up too miserly a share of revenues. In April the French Open’s organisers increased the prize money by 9.5% to \$72m, around 15% of the event’s expected revenue.

That seems like a straight-sets victory. But players want prize money to equal 22% of revenue by 2030. They have some cause: contestants in big American sports leagues such as the NBA and the NFL get wages worth around 50% of tournament revenues, even if they are injured or suspended. Tennis players are self-employed, so have less security, and rely on prize money and sponsorships for their earnings. Some, including the women’s world number one, Aryna Sabalenka, have said they might boycott the tournaments unless they cough up. For now, their battle with organisers seems stuck on a tie-break.



Photograph: Reuters

Weekend profile: Gwynne Shotwell, SpaceX's steady hand on the thrusters

Gwynne Shotwell, SpaceX's president and chief operating officer, has one regret about launching Elon Musk's red Tesla Roadster into space in 2018. "Starman should have been Starmam," she told an audience of women engineers that year, referring to the space-suited mannequin reclining in the driver's seat, "she should have had a ponytail coming out of her helmet". Mr Musk may be the public face of the firm that this week unveiled plans for the [biggest initial public offering ever](#), but Ms Shotwell is its commander.

When Mr Musk asked her to join SpaceX in 2002, Ms Shotwell almost turned him down. "It felt really risky," she recalls. Ms Shotwell, a mechanical engineer with a master's degree in applied mathematics and a member of America's National Academy of Engineering, was working at Microcosm, a space startup, at the time and found Mr Musk, then a newcomer to the industry, slightly naive. She thought he was underestimating how much he would have to invest, and wouldn't sign on until he committed at least \$50m. She had another wobble when Mr Musk offered to make her president in 2008. "What an idiot I would have been if I had said no," she reflected, before encouraging her audience to "take risks".

Hers paid off. With Ms Shotwell at the controls, SpaceX has rocketed above established companies and left governments on the

launch pad. These days it runs Earth's biggest space programme. Nearly 90% of the mass launched to orbit last year travelled on the firm's pioneering re-usable rockets.

Ms Shotwell is also a skilled saleswoman. She secured a contract to fly cargo to the International Space Station for NASA, which helped secure the startup's financial future. Her skills and personality complement those of Mr Musk. Where the billionaire is abrasive, Ms Shotwell is, in the words of Eric Berger, an author who has followed SpaceX, the "velvet glove". There is, though, no shortage of steel behind her cheery smile.

If the IPO is as stratospherically successful as predicted, Ms Shotwell will have little time to rest on her laurels. SpaceX must make its giant Starship rocket work; build NASA a lunar lander; keep its Starlink satellite-internet business growing; and deliver on its claim that space-based data centres are the future of AI. That is not to mention its long-term goal of putting humans on the Moon and Mars. But after 18 years at the top of the famously demanding company, she seems to have plenty of burn left in her.

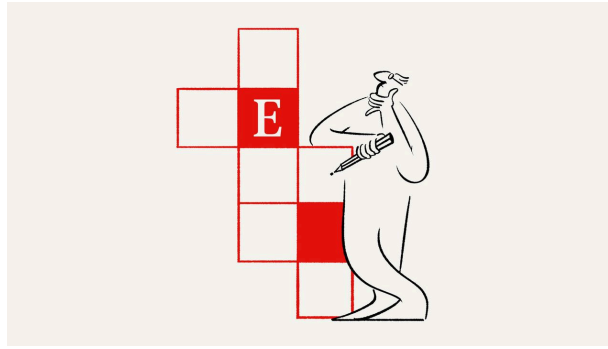


Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Add salt to oceans when running (6)

2 across - Tend to throw runes (5)

3 across - Scandinavian minor dictator at heart (6)

1 down - Antagonist misrepresented lack of progress (10)

Straight clues

1 across - Spring; a collection of tv shows (6)

2 across - Caregiver or medic (5)

3 across - Relating to Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Norway and Sweden (6)

1 down - A period of slow or nonexistent economic growth (10)



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Rob Blair, Harare, Zimbabwe

Lorelei Ritchie, Louisville, Kentucky

Ingo Schwanke, Manitoba, Canada

They all gave the correct answers of: Jackie Chan, Bill Gates, the Hollywood sign, Pulp and dogs. The theme is Quentin Tarantino films: Jackie Brown, Kill Bill (vol 1 and 2), Once Upon A Time In Hollywood, Pulp Fiction and Reservoir Dogs.

The questions were:

Monday: Which martial artist from Hong Kong had a Hollywood hit with the film "Rush Hour"?

Tuesday: Who along with his then wife Melinda, founded one of the world's largest charitable foundations in 2000?

Wednesday: Which famous American landmark had the letters "land" removed in 1949?

Thursday: Jarvis Cocker is the lead singer of which Britpop band?

Friday: Pomeranian, Havanese and Sheltie are breeds of which animal?

*Nature provides exceptions to
every rule.*

Margaret Fuller